

Episode 3: Once Upon a Time... (2)

I recently bought a new computer for work. A MacPro. I've finally become an intel-mac user. I increased the memory to 5GB and immediately put it to work. Whoa, it's fast! **Photoshop**, **TraceMan**, and **PaintMan** are all running smoothly at speeds I've never experienced in my personal history! Now if only my own hands could get faster... (distant stare).

Well then.

Immediate correction from last time (laughs). It was 1985 when I joined Toei Doga. I just counted on my fingers again because the years didn't seem to match up (bitter laugh). So, the story from that 1985.

My first job at Toei Doga was [**finishing progress**] in the finishing department. Yes, not colour direction, but starting with progress work first. I wanted to properly understand the production system first, so I deliberately asked to start with progress work, which I should have been relatively familiar with.

At Toei Doga, progress staff were assigned to both finishing and art backgrounds respectively, coordinating with production progress to manage finishing orders and cel deliveries for each work (background orders and deliveries for art backgrounds). This is still the same today. Usually, production progress manages everything by work, but Toei Doga's work production operates more like a "factory" system, creating multiple works in bulk and in parallel rather than by individual work, so this type of departmental management system becomes effective.

First I was assigned to *Dream Soldier Wingman* (夢戦士ウイングマン). I helped with the last few episodes of this work. Or rather, I was still like an apprentice at this point, learning the work know-how by following seniors. Soon after, I became in charge of the new programmes *Compore Kid* (コンポラキッド). After being involved from the launch of this programmes through about one cours, I finally transferred to [**inspection**].

As I wrote last time, Toei Doga's internal colour direction staff were called **[inspection]** back then (or rather, the internal department name is still **[inspection]** even now). Back then, for Toei works, not only background art but also the basic colours of characters were all decided by art designers. Character designers would pass character line drawings to art designers, who would add cel paint colour specifications and make them into cels. Props and background colour matching in scenes were all handled by passing line drawings to art for specification. So the job was "inspecting" whether finishing painted things correctly. Therefore, the jobs were **[colour direction]** and **[inspection]**, and there wasn't yet the concept of **[colour design]** as we know it today at Toei Doga.

Even though it was called **[inspection]**, by that time, checking painted TV series was already the job of each responsible production company, and actually checking cel deliveries was done for theatrical works, TV special works, and what were called "collaborative works" - subcontracted works from American animation production companies.

Well, my first work upon finally entering **[inspection]** was *Odin: Photon Sailer Starlight* (オーデューン光子帆船スターライト). I was put into helping with finishing inspection for this work. This was a theatrical work produced by **Nishizaki Yoshinobu** (西崎義展), who made *Space Battleship Yamato*, and was released in August of that year. I was brought in around late May, and at that point it was still mostly unfinished (laughs). I remember it being an extremely difficult situation in every way - schedule-wise, content-wise, and various other special circumstances (during the final push, every available space in the studio became a **saridashi** (撮出し) room [**saridashi** is the work of combining cels and backgrounds and giving filming instructions], and at peak moment, an extraordinary 17 directors were helping with **saridashi**).

So every day, day after day, I continued inspecting cels that came back painted from Korea, cut by cut.

Cel inspection - what kind of work is this? First, you secure the cels and in-between animation with a tool called a "tap." While checking the cel movements and stacking order with the time sheet, you literally flip through them one by one repeatedly, doing everything from correcting trace lines to checking and fixing paint mistakes, paint overflow, and scratches on the cel surface - it's that kind of steady (laughs) work. It's quite a world of "technique" and "craftsmanship" (laughs) - bamboo scrapers for removing overflow, correction pens, solutions for fixing small paint mistakes from the front of the cel.

So every day, from afternoon to night, sometimes until dawn, that work.

Every late night, cel deliveries were carried by hand from Korea. One day, that hand luggage included what appeared to be a souvenir jar of **kimchi**. But apparently that kimchi's sealing was terrible, and the kimchi juice had soaked into the cel deliveries. Naturally, the cut bags, time sheets, and in-between animation paper had absorbed it well, and every cut we opened was kimchi-pickled. We had to dry them and inspect the cels, but every time we flipped through them one by one, there was that "take this!" kimchi smell... (laughs).

Despite such struggles, we somehow managed to complete *Odin* at the very last minute. In the end, there was no staff screening at the studio, and by coincidence, on the opening day when I was going home in the morning, I saw the very first screening at a Shinjuku movie theatres.

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